

Rsync: A Backup Solution That's Easy on Your Pocket

Rsync is software that works on UNIX-like systems, and synchronises files and directories from one location to another by using delta encoding, which minimises file transfer. This article covers the backup features of rsync and compares these with those of tar, which is both the name of a file format as well as a program to handle such files.



In a production environment, administrators prefer to have proprietary backup/restore software due to their features and the support available. However, it would be useful to have simple open source backup/restore utilities, too, in place. Having an open source backup solution is cost-effective and users can customise it as per requirements.

This article covers the in-built utilities available in most of the Linux flavours such as tar and rsync. It also shares a few tips that can help in automating the backup process.

tar and rsync

These are the inbuilt backup/restore utilities or commands available in most of the Linux flavours.

Tar is an archiving program that helps to store many files together. This tool is beneficial when you need to put together a lot of files into a single file or stream with or without the help of some compression.

Rsync is a file copying tool. It can copy files to a remote

server over the network with the help of the `ssh` protocol to ensure data security. Rsync provides the delta-transfer algorithm, which means that it can send only the differences between the source files and the existing files in the destination. Rsync is widely used for backups and mirroring, and as an improved copy command for everyday use.

What to do if these utilities are not available in your Linux box, by default

Most Linux flavours have these RPMs by default. If not, you can get the relevant RPMs from the corresponding flavour of the Linux version that you use. For example, on a Fedora18 64-bit flavour, you can get this utility by installing `tar-1.26-9.fc18.x86_64` RPM. Similarly, the rsync utility is available from `rsync-3.0.9-5.fc18.x86_64` RPM as well.

How to get started

The man pages of tar and rsync are the best places to get started.